

THE MOTOWN UNIVERSE

Executive Development Memo #005 — Story Model, Continuity, Genre, Rating & Runtime

An alternate-reality “what if” • Fidelity Rating: 100% • Nerf Tolerance: 0%

1. The Decisions

STORY MODEL: 60% Serialized / 40% Standalone

GENRE: Musical Biographical Drama

RATING: PG-13

RUNTIME: 150–165 min standard • up to 180 min for events

How the universe connects: the films link through shared plot elements, settings, cast and characters, the same way Marvel's films did.

2. Serialized vs. Standalone: 60 / 40

Definition. The serialized share is the part of a film's story that continues threads from other TMU films or sets up new ones. The standalone share is the part that is complete within that film. Every film has a full beginning, middle and end, so a first-time viewer is never lost.

Phase	Films	Serialized / Standalone	Why
Phase 1 (2009–2013)	6	40 / 60	Origin stories. Each film has to win over new audiences on its own before the connections build up.
Phase 2 (2014–2016)	6	60 / 40	The audience knows the world, so threads carry across films.
Phase 3 (2017–2021)	11	70 / 30	The payoff phase, where years of setup come together.
Overall	23	60 / 40	The weighted average across all 23 films comes to about 60 / 40.

- **Why 60 / 40 fits Motown.** The real history is already connected. The same songwriters, the same band, the same building and the same boss show up in every artist's story. Crossovers aren't forced, because they already happened.
- **Why not higher.** Every artist deserves a film that stands as their own story. Turning a film into a setup for the next one would shortchange its lead, which the No-Nerf Mandate doesn't allow.

3. How the Films Connect

Type	Examples (all from real history)
Shared settings	Hitsville U.S.A. (2648 West Grand Blvd), Studio A ("the Snakepit"), the Fox Theatre, the Motortown Revue tour buses, and the later move to Los Angeles
Recurring characters	Berry Gordy as the thread running through the whole universe, plus the Funk Brothers, Holland–Dozier–Holland, Smokey Robinson and the rest of the Motown staff
Shared plot elements	The Friday Quality Control meetings, chart battles, the artist-development department, the civil rights era, and the business fights over contracts and royalties
Shared cast	One actor per real person across every film they appear in. See the continuity rules below.

4. Continuity Rules (Mandatory)

- **One master timeline.** Every scene in every film is pinned to a real date. Documented events (release dates, chart peaks, tours, signings) are fixed points that no film can move.
- **A Continuity Office inside Motown Productions.** It keeps the series bible, reviews every script and cut, and signs off before release.
- **One actor per real person.** Once cast, an actor keeps the role for the whole universe. The only exception is age. A child actor can hand off to an adult actor, for example, and the handoff is planned in advance.
- **Sets are built once.** The Hitsville and Studio A sets are permanent standing builds, so every film shows the same rooms.
- **Scenes seen from more than one film must match.** If a shared event appears in two films, the dialogue, staging and outcome agree, and only the point of view changes.
- **Dates on screen.** Every film shows a year or date card when the time period changes, so the audience always knows where they are on the timeline.

5. Genre & Subgenres

Primary genre: Musical Biographical Drama. These are real people and real events, told through their real music.

Subgenre	What it means for the Motown Universe
Backstage musical	Songs are performed only where they happened in life: sessions, rehearsals, concerts and TV appearances. Characters never break into song in the street. That keeps it historically accurate.
Period drama	Detroit and America from the late 1950s onward. Cars, clothes, hair and slang are researched to the year.
Historical / civil rights drama	The Jim Crow South, segregated venues and the civil rights movement, shown honestly and never softened.

Subgenre	What it means for the Motown Universe
Ensemble drama	The team-up structure. Stars, songwriters, musicians and executives share the screen.
Business / industry drama	How a family loan became a hit factory: contracts, competition, Quality Control and the fight for radio play.
Rise-and-fall drama	Real careers, with their real highs and real hardships.

Like the MCU, each film can lean on a different subgenre for its own feel while sharing one universe.

6. Rating: PG-13

- **It matches the blueprint.** Every film in the MCU's Infinity Saga was PG-13.
- **There's a strong genre precedent.** The top music biopics of the period, *Ray* (2004), *Walk the Line* (2005) and *Dreamgirls* (2006), were all PG-13.
- **It reaches the widest audience.** Motown was “The Sound of Young America,” so families and younger fans should be able to see it.
- **No-Nerf rule for the rating.** Real history is never softened or cut to get a PG-13. Racism, violence, addiction and tragedy stay in the story. They're handled with care and framing, not left out.

7. Runtime: Long but Reasonable

Film type	Runtime
Standard film (target)	150–165 min (2h30–2h45). The target average is about 155 min.
Minimum for any film	140 min
Phase-ending or team-up event film	Up to 180 min (3h00)

- **Why it runs long.** A music biopic has to fit a full life story and full performances. Signature songs are shown in full, not cut into montages, because a shortened performance would shortchange the artist.
- **Why it stays reasonable.** Keeping standard films under 2h45 still allows a normal number of showings per day for theaters. The 3-hour cap is saved for the biggest events, as the MCU did. For comparison, *Ray* ran about 2.5 hours, and the MCU's biggest team-up films ran about 2.5 to 3 hours.

TMU is a fan-made alternate-reality concept. It has no connection to Motown Records, Universal Music Group or Marvel Studios.